

01

THE DEPENDENCE VIEW — morality needs religion □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Divine Command Theory (DCT): an act is right because God commands it; morality is grounded in, and motivated by, God's will.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): The dependence view holds that morality requires religion for its authority, motivation or ultimate sanction, but these three claims must be assessed separately.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Without God, the view argues, the ultimate authority of moral obligation becomes difficult to explain. □

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

"One can have morality without religion but not religion without morality" (2022 PYQ): □□

ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): The dependence view holds that morality requires religion for its authority, motivation or ultimate sanction, but these three claims must be assessed separately.

02

THE INDEPENDENCE VIEW — autonomous morality □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Euthyphro dilemma (Plato): Is the pious loved by the gods because it is pious, or pious because it is loved? □

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Horn 1 (good because commanded) → morality is arbitrary (God could command cruelty and it'd be "good").

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Kant: morality rests on reason & autonomy (the categorical imperative), not on God's command.

ANSWER LINE: Moral obligation can be grounded independently in reason, welfare, virtue, human dignity or the reduction of suffering, even when religion strengthens motivation.

03

THE INTERACTION VIEW — mutual influence (2023 PYQ) □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religion and morality are conceptually distinguishable yet historically interactive: religion shapes moral formation, while moral criticism reforms religious practice.

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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religion and morality are conceptually distinguishable yet historically interactive: religion shapes moral formation, while moral criticism reforms religious practice.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Morality influences/refines religion: moral conscience critiques religious practice (prophets against ritualism; reform movements against caste/sati); a religion is judged by its ethical fruits (James). □□

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Empirically: religion can promote pro-social behaviour and (misused) sanction intolerance/violence — the relation is contingent, not automatic. □□

ANSWER LINE: Religion and morality are conceptually distinguishable yet historically interactive: religion shapes moral formation, while moral criticism reforms religious practice.

04

COMPARISON GRID □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Balanced conclusion: the Euthyphro shows morality cannot be wholly reducible to divine command (else arbitrary), so morality has autonomy; yet religion powerfully motivates and sustains morality, and morality purifies religion — hence the interaction view, not strict dependence, is soundest.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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05

FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

2. □ The sentence commonly rendered as "If God does not exist, everything is permitted" is a summary of a Dostoevskian theme, not a safe verbatim quotation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Kant grounds moral obligation in rational autonomy and relates religion to the requirements of practical reason.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

2. □ The sentence commonly rendered as "If God does not exist, everything is permitted" is a summary of a Dostoevskian theme, not a safe verbatim quotation.

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ The Euthyphro dilemma asks whether divine approval constitutes goodness or responds to goodness.

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Interactive relation." (2023) → §3.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Religion without morality] "Can there be a religion without morality?" (2024) → §1.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Influence] "Does religion influence moral behaviour?

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

1. [Asymmetry] "'Morality without religion, but not religion without morality.' Discuss." (2022) → §1.

ANSWER LINE: 1. [Asymmetry] "'Morality without religion, but not religion without morality.' Discuss." (2022) → §1.

PARITY BENCH — grounding morality with and without God □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The key analytical distinction is between what makes an act right, what justifies belief in its rightness and what motivates an agent to perform it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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